RISERS LEAGUE SPONSORSHIP TRENDS

1. Business Understanding

In order to expand its sponsorship portfolio, Harrington FC has hired our agency to: (i) identify up to five commercial trends that are pertinent to Harrington FC, and (ii) suggest one category and brand for a new category-level relationship prior to the 2026–27 season. This paper examines current partnership data across the Risers League.

Harrington FC's men's team sit in the top half of the Risers League; the women's team leads its league and is drawing record attendances, prompting talks to host all women's fixtures at the main stadium. The club has recently opened youth academies in the UK, USA, Australia, Germany and France, and has chosen not to renew several expiring category partners (Nivea is still under review).

Every trend in this report is backed by the dataset itself, and the final recommendation sticks to the brief's definition of a category partnership, something like an Official Automotive Partner, rather than a kit deal or stadium naming rights.

2. Data Understanding

The dataset has 800 active sponsorship deals from across the Risers League: men's and women's clubs, the League itself, and the National Governing Bodies. Each deal has 14 fields attached to it, such as sponsor name, sponsor location, category, rights holder, which team or teams the deal covers, sponsorship tier, inventory, start and end dates, deal length, status and value. Club names are fictional and deal values are simulated. A few things stood out before any analysis started.

Field	Observation
Deal Status	100% 'Active': this is a live-book snapshot, not a full historical archive
Sponsor Inventory	Populated for only 119 of 800 rows (15%): only shirt, kit and stadium-type deals carry inventory detail
Category	201 distinct labels, several as compound strings (e.g. 'Computers & software; Internet & IT services'), needing grouping for analysis
Simulated Deal Value	Ranges from £50k to £40bn; heavily right-skewed (median £500k, mean £63.5m)

Table 1: Data quality observations noted before analysis

3. Data Preparation

- **Date parsing:** Deal start and end dates were converted to proper date values, and a start year was pulled out for each deal so we could look at trends over time.
- **Outlier treatment:** One deal (Doo Group sponsoring Hendricks FC as a sleeve sponsor in Capital Markets and Trading, listed at £40 billion) is 40 times bigger than the next-largest deal in the dataset (£1 billion), and doesn't match its own category or inventory type. It looks like a data-entry error, so it has been excluded from all value totals, though it is still visible and flagged in the workbook. It doesn't affect deal-count figures.
- **Category consolidation:** The 201 category labels were mapped to 23 broader category groups for the scoring models (workbook sheet 4). The trend figures in this report quote the original labels, so that specific categories such as Betting can be compared directly.
- **Property normalisation:** 'Womens', missing its apostrophe, was merged into "Women's" so the gender split wouldn't undercount those deals.

- **Scoring:** Categorical fields such as sponsorship tier and inventory were converted to numeric scores, min-max normalised, and combined into a weighted Deal Strength Score for each deal (workbook sheets 5 to 8).
- **Segmentation:** Harrington FC's own 38 deals were separated out, so we could see which categories the club already has covered versus what other clubs in the league hold.

4. Analysis: Five Key Trends

Trend 1: Kit deals dominate the money, but not the deal count

Sportswear makes up only 4% of all deals in the league, 33 out of 799 once the outlier is excluded, but it accounts for half of all contracted value: £5.38 billion out of £10.83 billion. That is almost entirely down to six club kit deals with Nike, Adidas and Puma worth between £600 million and £1 billion each (£5.0 billion together). A category partnership, which is what the club is actually after, is a much smaller kind of deal, so the right comparison is something like Betting (£442 million across 38 deals) or Insurance and Pensions (£553 million across 9 deals), not kit.

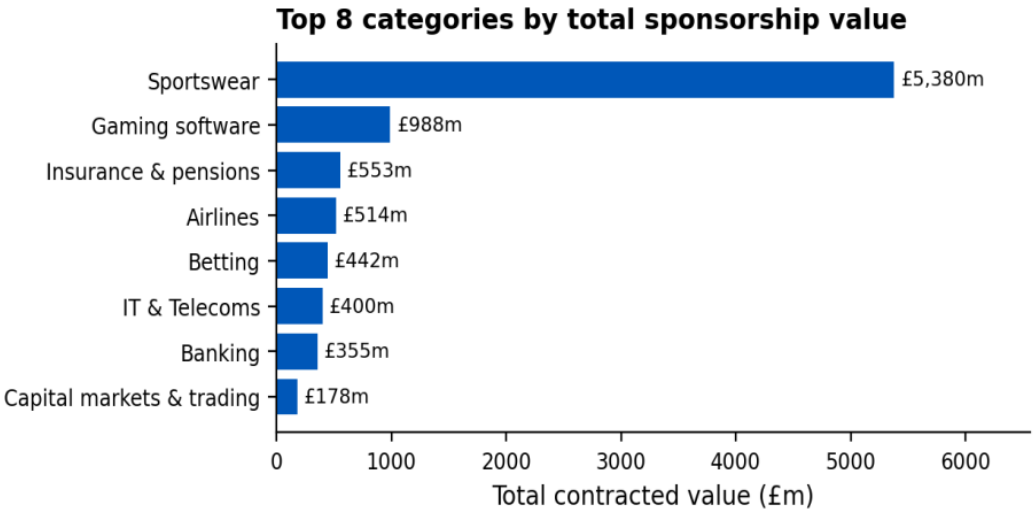


Figure 1: Total sponsorship value by category, top eight categories in the league

Trend 2: Most deals in this league are short-term

Just over half of all deals, 410 of 800, run for a single season, and 62% of the deals that are active right now (499 of 800) started on the same day, 1 July 2025. At the other end, 621 of the 800 deals (78%) are due to end on 30 June 2026. Sponsorship in the Risers League behaves like a season-by-season market rather than a long-term one. Harrington FC's own principal partners are the exception: Etihad Airways runs to 2028 and Nike to 2030. Even so, 21 of the club's 38 deals end on 30 June 2026. The upside is that the club could realistically run a fast pitch process and trial a new category partner on a one- or two-year deal before committing further.

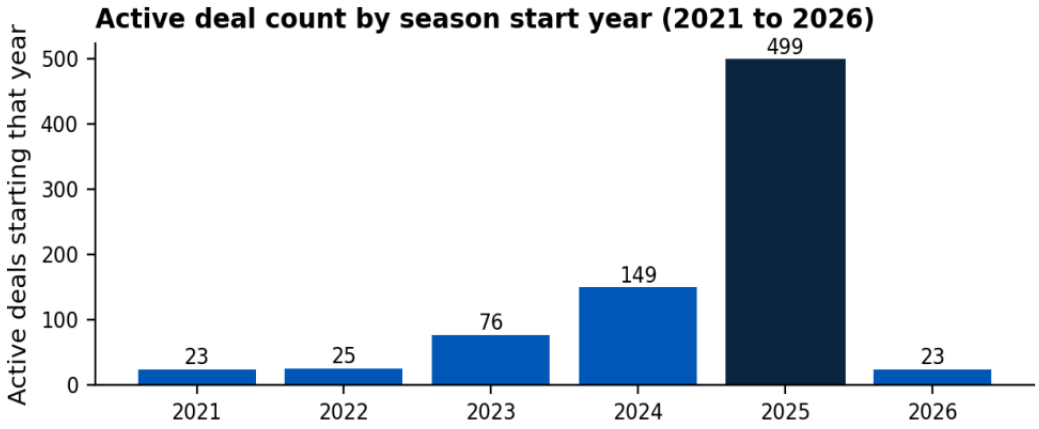


Figure 2: Number of active deals by season start year, 2021 to 2026

Trend 3: Betting has the most deals in the league, and a few standout spenders

Betting has more deals than any other category, 38 in total, about 4.8% of the whole market, but most of that is low-tier: 16 of the 38 deals sit at entry-level Official Sponsor tier, and the category averages £11.6 million a deal. A few operators buck that trend. Betano's £50 million Major Partner deal with Kennedy FC is the second-highest-value betting deal held by any single club in the league, beaten only by Stake.com's £60 million deal with Serrano FC. It also has the highest Deal Strength Score of the 46 betting and gaming deals held by league clubs (workbook sheet 10), and it is about four and a half times what Harrington FC currently gets from its own Bet365 deal. That Bet365 deal sits at Official Sponsor tier for £11 million and expires on 30 June 2026, right as the club is thinking about its next move.

Trend 4: The women's team's success isn't reflected in sponsorship money yet

Deals that cover only the women's team add up to just £26 million across 20 deals, which is 0.24% of all the value in the league. Compare that to deals covering both men's and women's rights together, worth £8.05 billion across 231 deals, or men's-only deals, worth £2.76 billion across 548 deals. Harrington FC's women's team is top of its league and drawing record crowds that are pushing the club to talk about a stadium move, but none of that is showing up commercially yet. A partner that leans into the women's team's momentum would genuinely stand out, because almost no one else in the league is doing this.

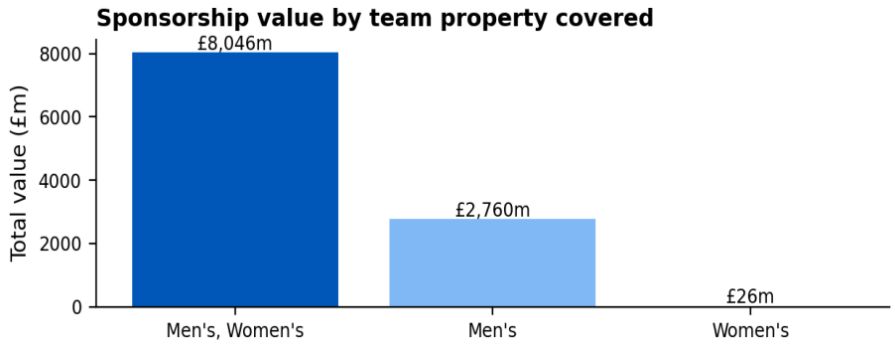


Figure 3: Total sponsorship value by team property covered

Trend 5: Sponsors are mostly UK and US based, despite the club going international

49% of sponsor deals in the league are with UK companies, and another 17% with US companies, 66% combined. Only 40 deals, about 5%, come from sponsors based in Germany, France or Australia, three of the five countries where Harrington FC has just opened youth academies. So, the club's international footprint hasn't yet translated into international sponsorship money. This is worth keeping an eye on for the future, though it doesn't change the recommendation below.

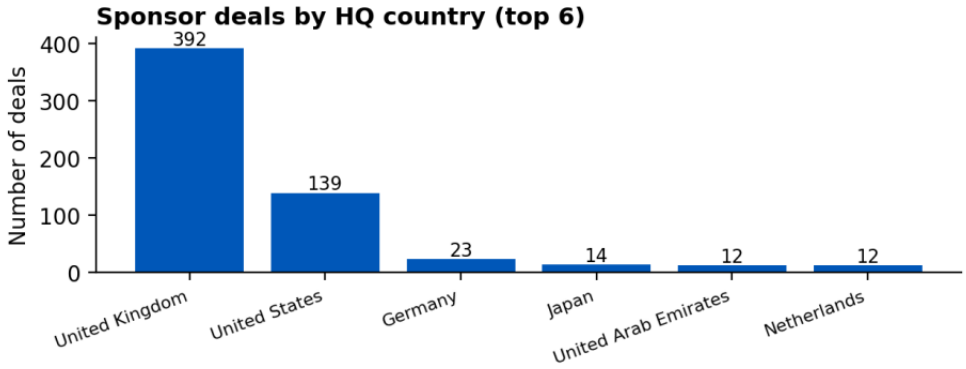


Figure 4: Number of sponsor deals by sponsor headquarters country, top six countries (single-country sponsors)

5. Evaluation

These five trends all come straight from the 800-row dataset and hold together as a picture. A small number of big kit deals skew the total market value (Trend 1), sitting on top of a market that's otherwise mostly short, lower-value deals (Trend 2). Betting's mix of low-tier volume with a few big spenders (Trend 3), plus the gender gap (Trend 4) and the geography gap (Trend 5), all point the same way: Harrington FC's next category deal is more about picking the right tier and timing than about chasing the single biggest category.

To test this, a weighted sum model in the workbook (sheet 11) ranks the category groups across the 542 team deals held by league clubs, using median deal value (30%), sponsorship tier (20%), deal length (20%), share of deals (20%) and time left to run (10%).

Rank	Category group	WSM score	Note
1	Sportswear & Equipment	0.141	Kit deals, outside the scope of a category partnership
2	Betting & Gaming	0.094	Highest-ranked category eligible for a category partnership
3	Financial Services	0.077	Next option if the club rules out betting
4	Technology & IT	0.061	

Table 2: Top four category groups in the weighted sum model

The main data quality issue is the £40 billion outlier, which was excluded from value calculations; it doesn't affect the deal-count trends (2 and 3). Category labels aren't fully standardised either, but that doesn't change the overall rankings used above.

6. Recommended Category and Brand Partner

Recommended category	Official Betting Partner, Major Partner tier
Recommended brand	Betano

Table 3: Recommended category and brand partner for 2026/27

This fits the brief's own definition of a category partnership, an Official [X] Partner along the same lines as its Official Automotive Partner example, rather than a kit or stadium naming rights deal. The brief also says the brand doesn't need to come from within the dataset, and Betano already being in it isn't a problem. If anything, it helps, because it gives real evidence of what Betano is prepared to pay for a Risers League club rather than a guess.

Think of this as an upgrade rather than starting from scratch. Harrington FC's current betting partner, Bet365, is at Official Sponsor tier for £11 million, and that deal runs out on 30 June 2026, right at the start of the 2026/27 season. So, there is already a clean, natural point to switch category partner without cutting anything short.

Betano is the best brand fit we found. It already has a £50 million Major Partner deal with Kennedy FC, the second-biggest betting deal held by any single club in the league behind Stake.com's £60 million deal with Serrano FC, and about four and a half times what Harrington FC currently gets from Bet365. That spend shows Betano is willing to pay Major Partner money for a Risers League club, not just Official Sponsor-level exposure, which is where most betting deals in this league sit. Moving up from Official Sponsor to Major Partner would also put the deal closer in size to the club's principal partners.

Worth being upfront about the downside too. Betting is still the most crowded category in the league by deal count, so Harrington FC needs to stand out through the tier and quality of the inventory it offers, sleeve or training-kit rights, for example, rather than through the category itself. Any deal should also include the usual UK gambling advertising safeguards, whistle-to-whistle restrictions and responsible gambling messaging, given the club runs youth academies. Taking all of that together, the combination of a well-timed contract expiry and a proven big spender already active in the league makes Betano, at Major Partner tier, the strongest option for 2026/27.

The supporting analysis, pivot tables, scoring models and full cleaned dataset are in the accompanying workbook.